UX CASE STUDY

Redesigning student enrolment portal

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Significant Steps

Identifying & testing Problems

Creating Solutions

Analysis & Reflection

Who is this for?

RMIT Students

As a student at RMIT, I was able to identify that the Enrolment Online portal was in major need of revision. In this project, I test with people who have never used the website before, in order to obtain a fresh perspective on how it performs.

PROJECT OVERVIEW

What problem does this case study address?

Choosing a semester to enrol

For this case study, i will be talking about my process of addressing just the single issue in order to highlight my process and not get caught up in the finished product.

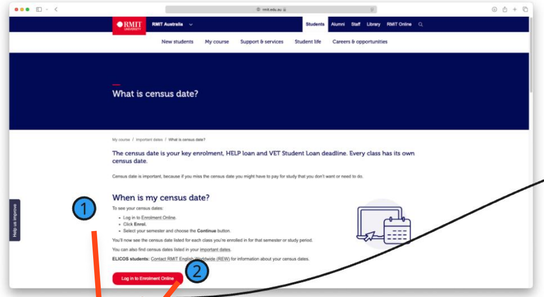
Note that this case study is not a description of the full project, rather an outline of my process, focusing on addressing just one issue.

Where does this begin?

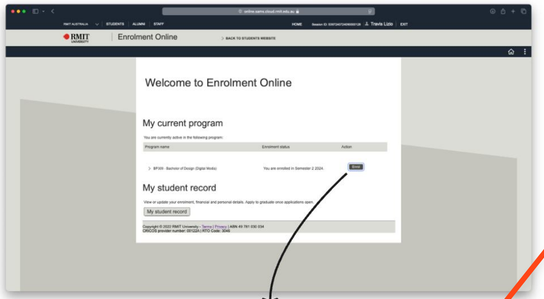
Identifying & testing problems

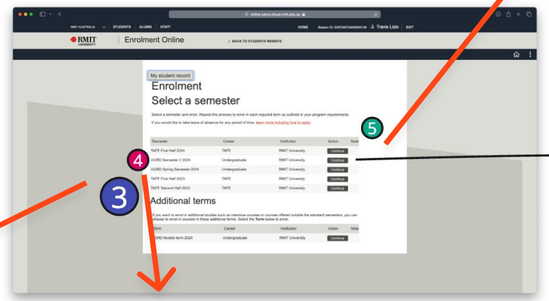
I conduct multiple layers of research into the website to first break down and validate problems. Each step helps understand what the problem is. Understanding problems is crucial in identifying solutions.

Where are the problems?



THE CONTEXT DISPLAYED BY RMIT'S WEBSITE IS GOOD, HOWEVER TO PERFORM SUCH A TASK SHOULD BE AUTOMATIC

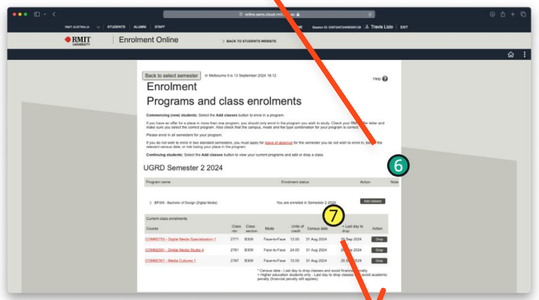




DATES ARE NOT SORTED CHRONOLOGICALLY, AND THERE IS NO INDICATION OF THE CURRENT SEMESTER

USE OF COMPUTER ABBREVIATIONS (UGRD) IS CONFUSING TO READ

MESSY AND OLD 'PHP' TABLE DESIGN



RELEVANT INFORMATION (CENSUS DATE) IS NOT EASILY FOUND

Illustrating these problems using usability principles found in books: Don't Make me Think (Steve Krug), Designing With the Mind in Mind (Jeff Johnson), 10 Usability Heuristics (NN Group) is critical in validating problems before getting people involved to test them.

How can i test these?

Introducing usability tests

I split this problem into two parts for testing, and was able to source 3 seperate participants for these tests. The goal is to repeat these tests once i have a redesign, and directly compare the results to see if my redesign performed better in these categories.

What tests did i run?

①

Think Aloud

A moderated test that involves asking the participant to complete a task while expressing their thoughts. I wanted to understand what the participant clicked on, and why they clicked on it, or what else they considered.

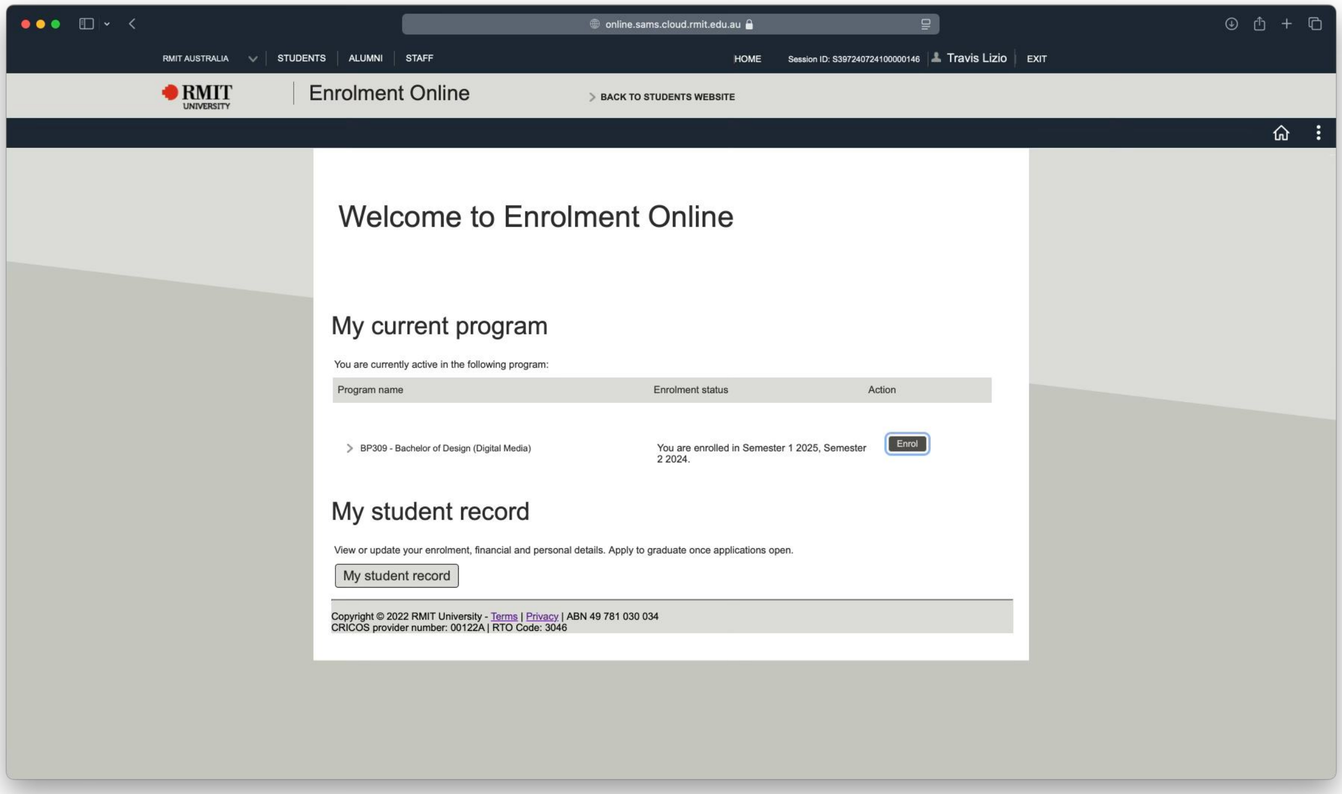
②

Trunk Test

Also moderated, the participant is shown cards and primed with their meanings. Once they know what each card is for, the participant is shown the screen and told to drag each card to its corresponding element, as quickly as possible.

Moderated testing refers to testing in the same room as the participant, and observing them to understand how they think. This is in contrast to Unmoderated testing, where the goal is to find the common or general thoughts of multiple participants remotely to process into data like heat-maps, or click-through rates.

How did it go? part 1. Think aloud



PARTICIPANT 1

Correctly identified the program they were a part of, and clicked the enrolment button immediately

PARTICIPANT 2

Also immediately identified and clicked on the enrolment button immediately

PARTICIPANT 3

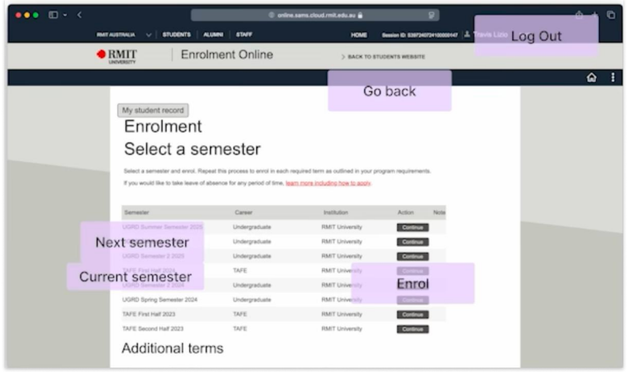
Immediately identified the program they were a part of, and clicked the enrolment button

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I wanted to test if participants would choose to navigate through the directory to enrol, or go straight to the ‘enrol’ button on the current page. All users clicked straight into the ‘enrol’ button, which I thought was interesting, and I know to keep the enrol button available on the first page of my redesign.

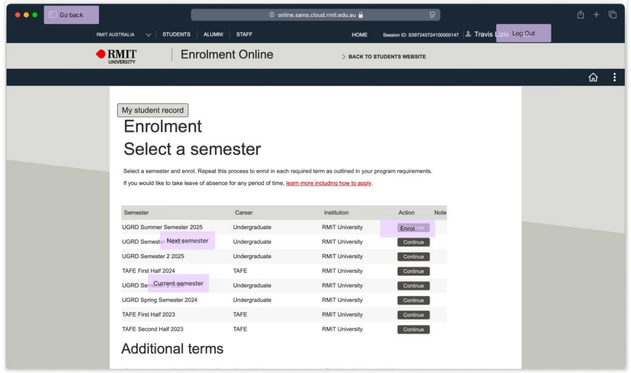
How did it go? part 2. Trunk test

PARTICIPANT 1



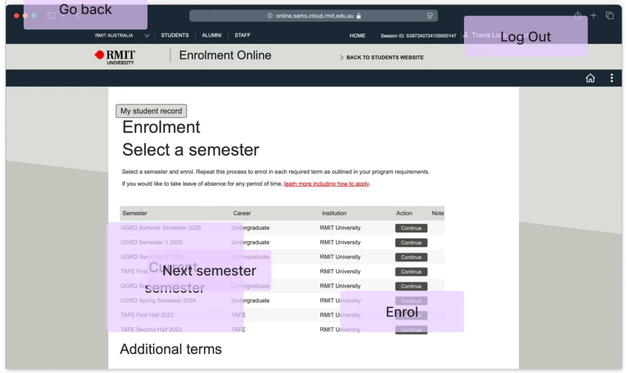
Was able to assign all except the ‘back’ and ‘Enrol’ labels without any issue.

PARTICIPANT 2



All but ‘current semester’ were easy for the user to find.

PARTICIPANT 3



Was able to correctly assign everything easily, except for current and next semester

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The goal of these tests was to validate the issues i had initially found myself, and potentially find more. Users generally had no trouble with most of the UX of the page layout, however when it came to important functions, like enrolling in the current or next semester, users experienced much friction.

What am i supposed to do with these problems?

Creating Solutions

Now that i had created, validated, and tested the problems i had identified in navigating this part of the website, i am able to begin generating solutions

What to fix first?

Forced ranking

When managing a project as large as a website redesign, it is important to maintain a position over the scope of the project. One way to stay on top of time, is to plan for what to fix first by weighing each tasks performance in a method called ‘Forced Ranking’.

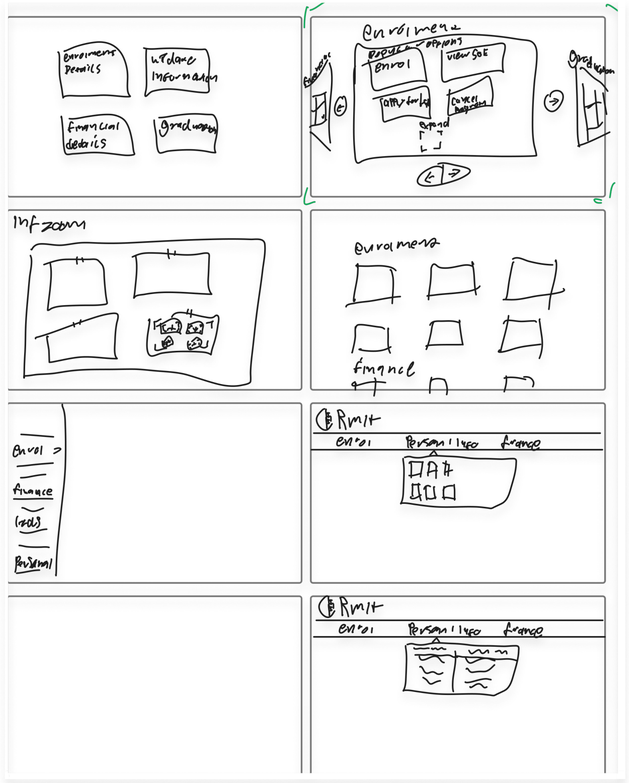
Idea / Feature Name	Benefit	Usefulness	Frequency of Use	Change in behaviour	Total
Modernise task completion layout	3	3	4	3	13
Modernise program enrolment	1	2	4	2	9
Modernise and consolidate dashboard / landing screen	2	1	1	1	5

It is important to mention that this case study is not about the most solving the most important, complicated, or impactful task, but the one most rich in process. Other problems were solved for the project as a whole, but that is outside the scope of this case study.

How did i solve the problems?

Ideation - Crazy 8s

I had a lot of interesting ideas that stemmed from the test results, and I was excited to put them on paper in crazy 8's, but more importantly for my new ideas to emerge from these crazy 8's, which ultimately played the biggest part in my redesign.



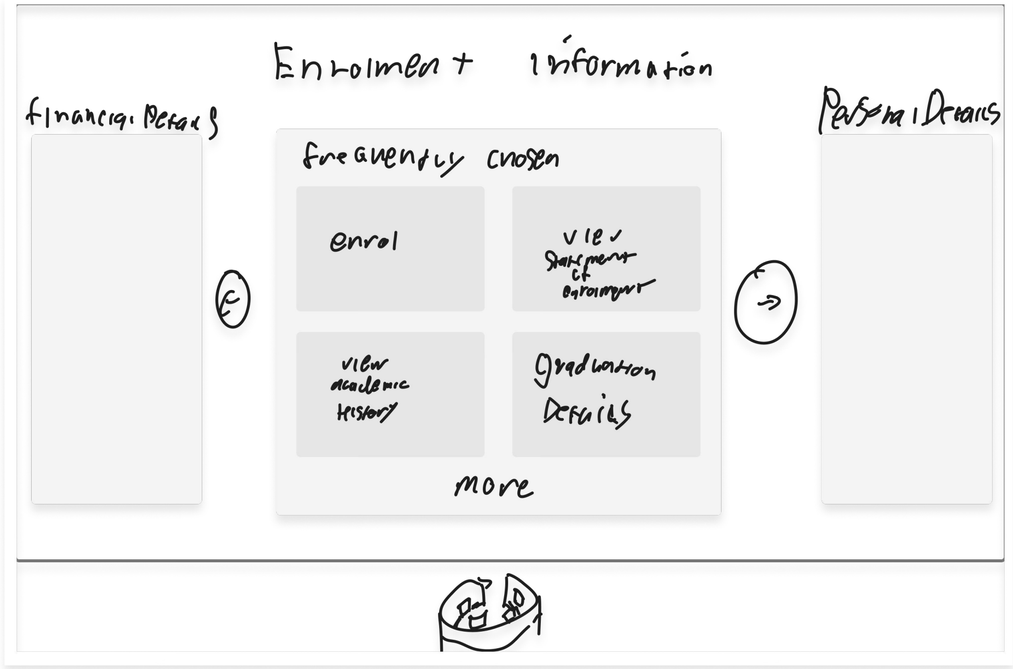


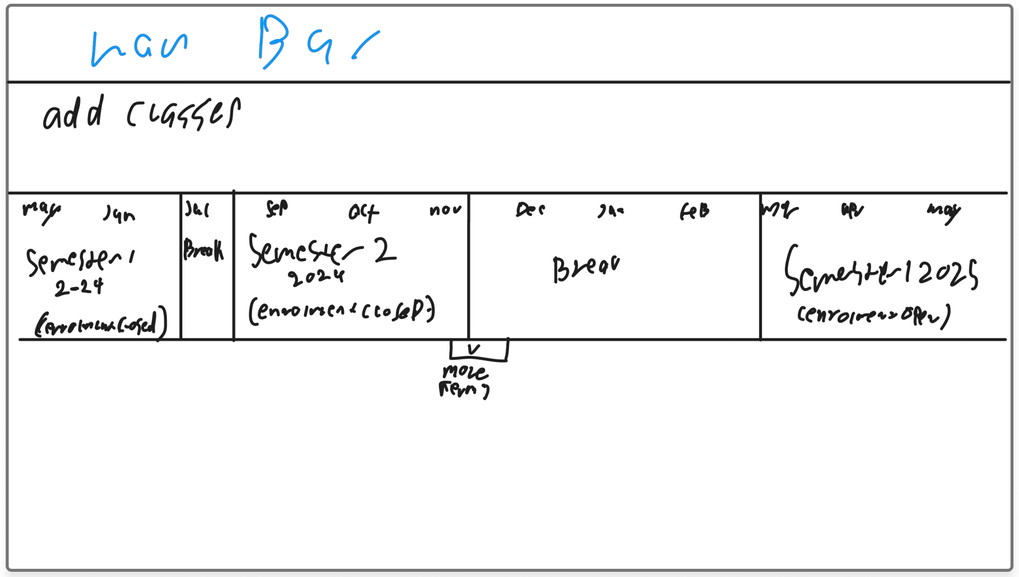
Diverging is the act of generating a wide range of ideas to maximise creativity and explore different possibilities. Techniques like Crazy 8's encourage rapid ideation, which is essential for breaking conventional patterns and producing diverse, meaningful concepts.
They might look like gibberish, which is a good thing. It signifies that not much time was spent on each idea, which boosts divergence.

What comes after crazy 8's?

Ideation - wireframes

Wireframes are a great way to improve the fidelity of Crazy 8's, and provide us with the ability to pick and choose the best elements from all the sketches to combine into one screen. I experimented with using Figma's shapes features to quickly block out elements in the wireframes, instead of sketching each element by hand. These wireframes are mid-fidelity improvements / the next step following Crazy 8's.





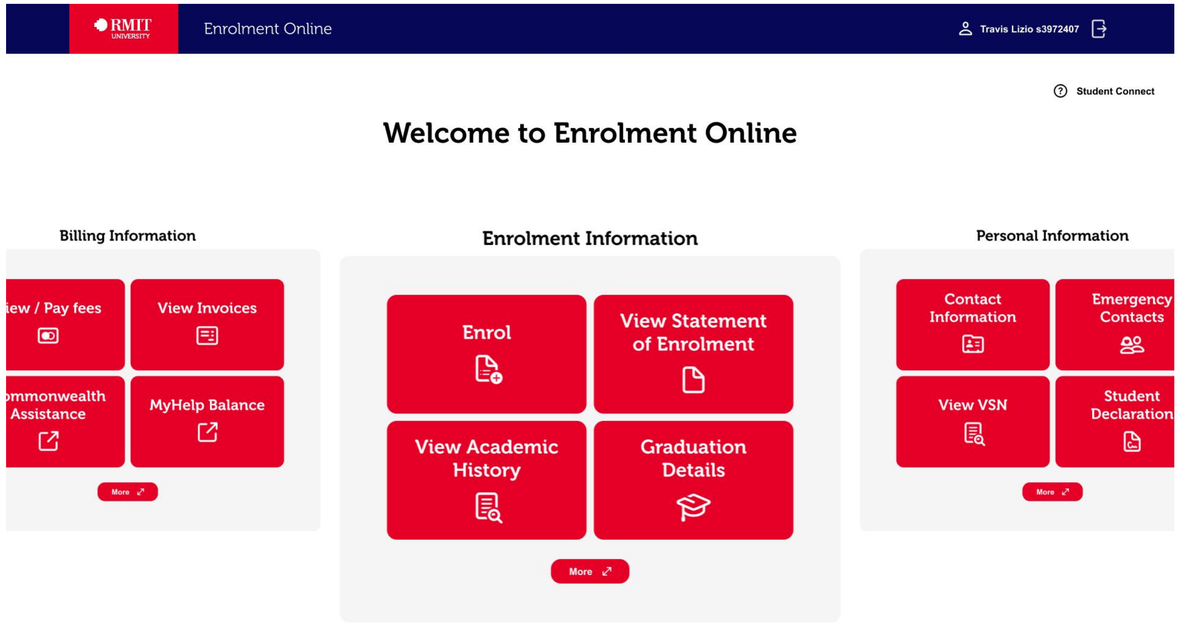
Ideally, i would have created Wire-flows in this section, however, since the crazy 8's already had a basic overview of the navigating the website, i decided not to re-draw most of the navigation, instead opting to just add what was necessary to visualise interaction, and use a combination of Crazy 8's and wireframes in the Prototype.

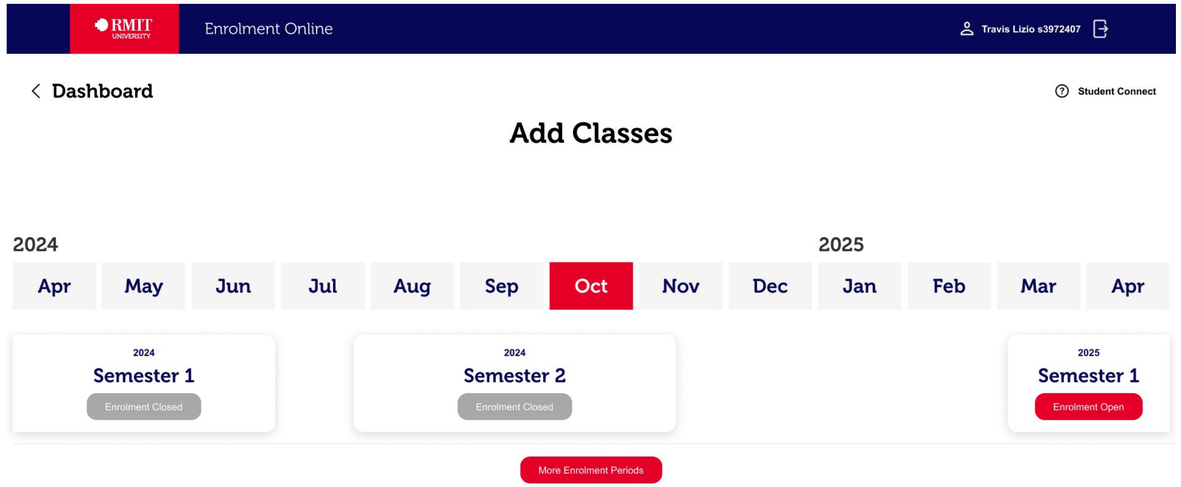
CREATING SOLUTIONS

Here comes the fun part!

Prototyping

Always something to look forward to, but never something to rush. Designing in figma is quite rewarding, and represents a significant milestone in the process of creating a redesign, allowing me to test on users.





I would have ideally tested my low-fidelity sketches quite frequently, however this is something i overlooked, and led to a process that, while i am not proud to present as it is, i feel is important to uncover and learn from. Though the end products were fine, it is important to remember that the goal of the case study is not to show off my end product, but what i learned and the methods i used to get there.

What am i supposed to do with these problems?

Analysis and Reflection

Just as, if not more important than the design process, is validating those designs and being able to reflect on the process as a whole, to identify what i would improve on, and the shortcomings of my final designs.

What tests did i run?

①

Think Aloud

A moderated test that involves asking the participant to complete a task while expressing their thoughts. I wanted to understand what the participant clicked on, and why they clicked on it, or what else they considered.

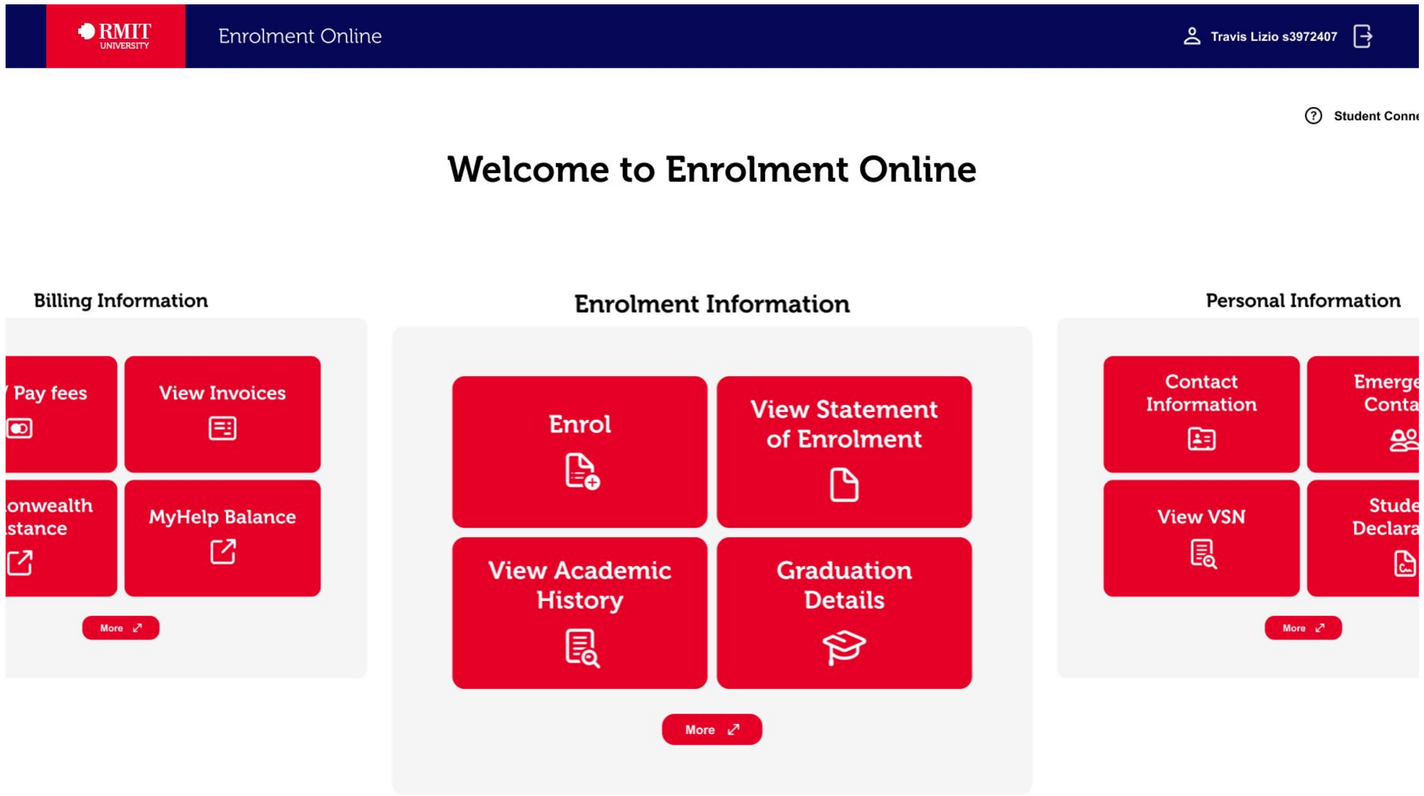
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Trunk Test

Also moderated, the participant is shown cards and primed with their meanings. Once they know what each card is for, the participant is shown the screen and told to drag each card to its corresponding element, as quickly as possible.

You might notice that this is a direct copy of what was tested in the identifying problems section. Simply put, it is the exact same. For good reason: I am performing A/B tests on my design compared to the original. To do this, i need the original design's tests to be the exact same as the redesign's tests.

How did it go? part 1. Think aloud



PARTICIPANT 1

Found the overwhelming red to be quite jarring, but was able to correctly identify and press on the enrol button.

PARTICIPANT 2

There was no hesitation behind the user's ability to click on the enrol button

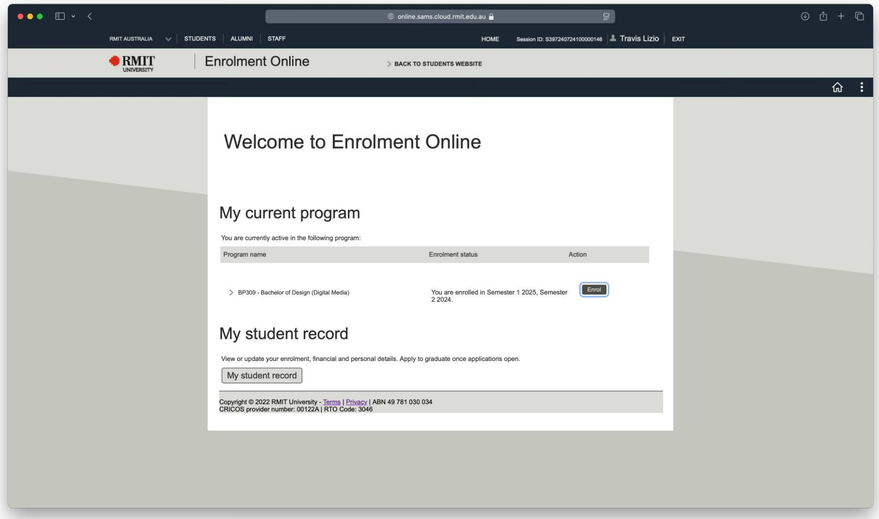
PARTICIPANT 3

Found and clicked on the enrolment button instantly, without distraction.

Ideally, my redesign's test would have reflected that of the original: being just one screen. However overall, I believe my redesign introduced a nice spin on what the front page should look like, however I would agree that the colors come off a bit strong.
Notably, it would have helped to conduct testing for organising these categories, rather than assigning based on my personal experience.

A

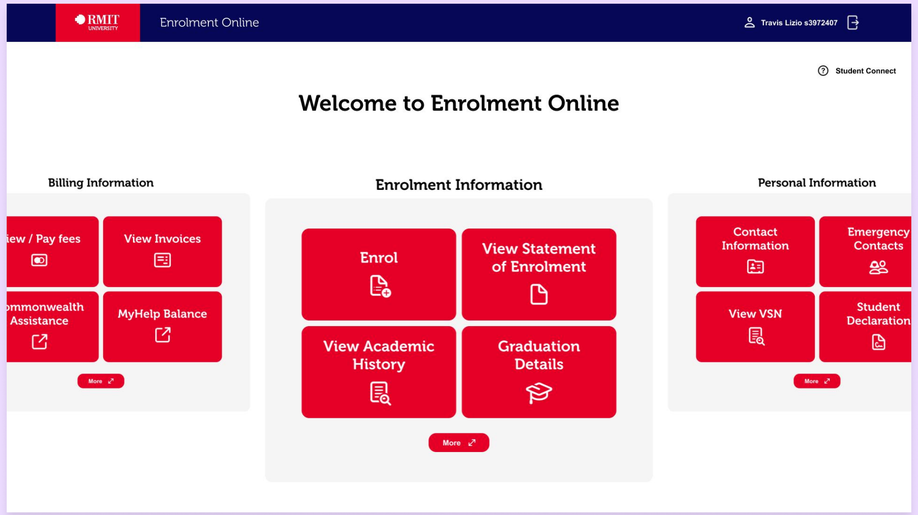
ORIGINAL



Users all instantly identified the correct button to press, with one noting the program they were enrolling in. Overall, users had little issue with this screen, the main problems being aesthetic.

B

REDESIGN

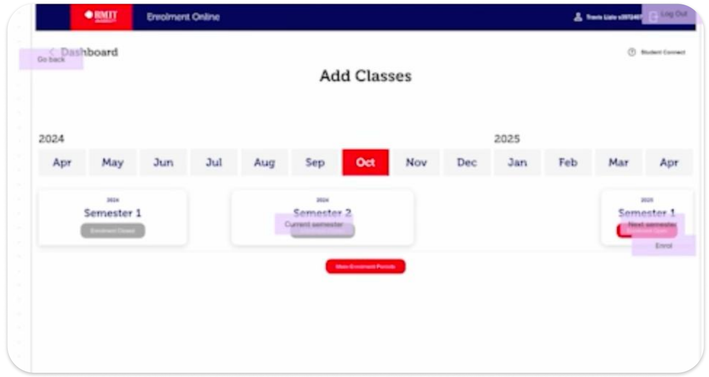


Users were overall able to complete the task to the same degree of success as they were on the old design. It is good to know that my design did not reduce their ability to perform a task that was already not a problem for them, while improving the task flow by reducing distractions.

ANALYSIS AND REFLECTION

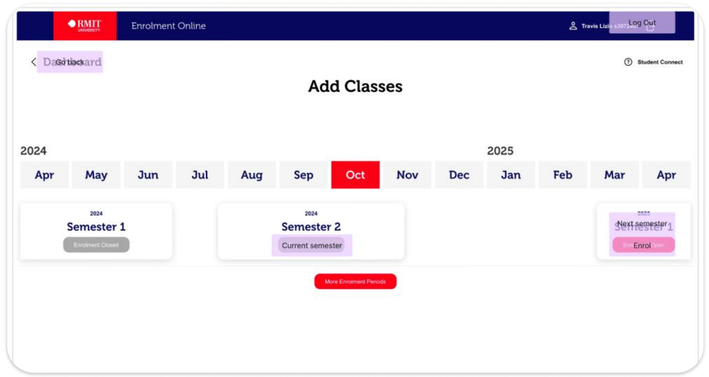
How did it go? part 2. Trunk test

PARTICIPANT 1



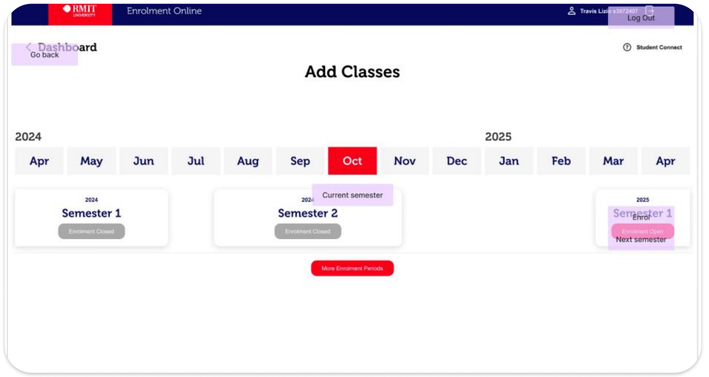
Was able to correctly identify each element on the screen without delay, with full confidence.

PARTICIPANT 2



Was able to almost instantly drag and drop each card to it’s corresponding element, without hesitation

PARTICIPANT 3



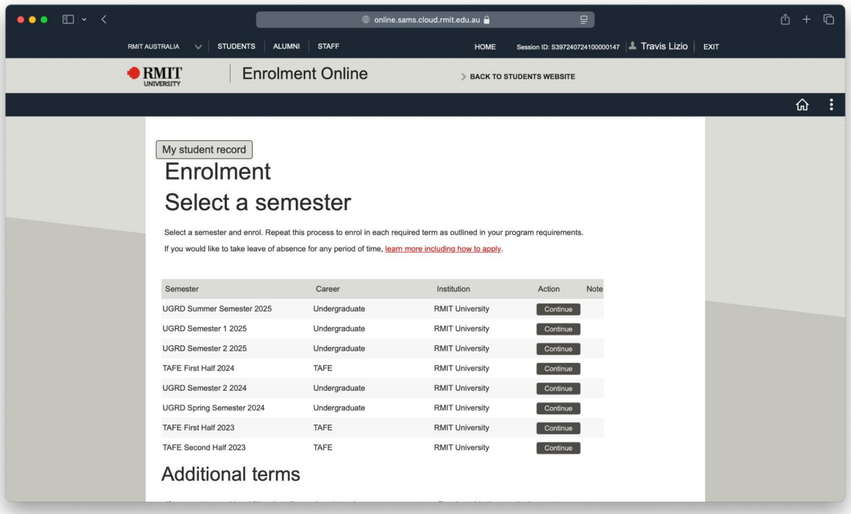
The user was able to assign everything to their correct place without difficulty

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It was rewarding to see the immediately noticeable increase in user’s ability to identify the current and next semester, while remaining at similar performance levels for tasks they didn’t struggle with. I would say that my design is quite successful, however I feel that I could have done more tests on this page, and in the future i would test for more complicated tasks, now knowing that the foundations are solid.

A

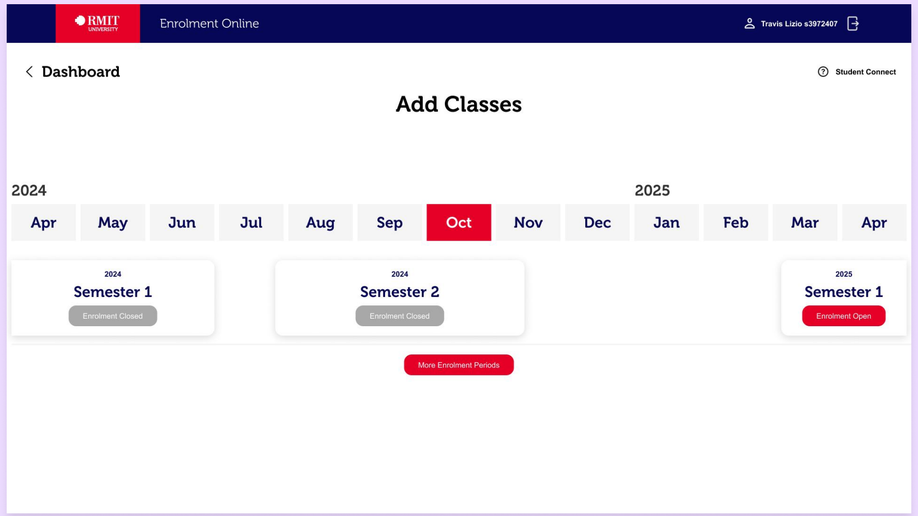
ORIGINAL



Overall, Every user struggled to find the current semester due to no indication of current date / month, or indication of enrolment periods.

B

REDESIGN



Though my redesign has more independent visual elements than the original, Users were able to identify the elements they needed to more effectively and much quicker due to the relevancy of these elements. Additionally, no function was lost.

ANALYSIS AND REFLECTION

What did i learn?

①

Diverging is key

It is super, super important to be able to diverge from your initial idea. It could be the best idea you will have, but you never know until you generate *more* ideas, and analyse them

②

Testing at every stage

If i could do it all again, i would have been testing at every stage of the project, not just the beginning and end. There were so many opportunities that i missed, and i believe that was one of the pitfalls of my project.

③

Variety in testing

In hindsight, it would have been quite valuable to perform more detailed tests, potentially testing different groups of tests on different groups of participants in order not to overwhelm them.

Thanks!

Hope you enjoyed going through that as much as i enjoyed making it.